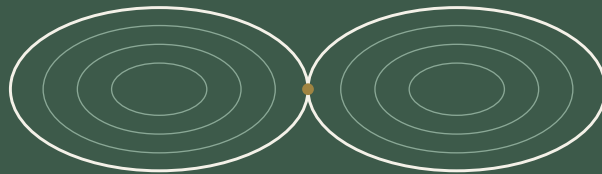


V4 · HUMANIZED AUDIO TOURS

Musée de l'Orangerie

Monet's Water Lilies & the Walter-Guillaume Collection



The two oval rooms · Camille Lefèvre, architect, with Claude Monet · 1927

*« l'illusion d'un tout sans fin,
d'une onde sans horizon et sans rivage. »*

the illusion of an endless whole,
a wave without horizon and without shore

CLAUDE MONET

on the Water Lilies, in conversation with Roger Marx, 1909

Musée de l'Orangerie

A V4 humanized walking audio tour — thirty tracks, about one hour and forty minutes.

The Orangerie is small. You can see it in an hour and a half. But it contains, on the ground floor, two oval rooms designed by Claude Monet for his eight Water Lilies — paintings the artist worked on for the last twelve years of his life, while losing his wife, losing a son, and going nearly blind. And on the lower level, the Walter-Guillaume collection: one hundred and forty-eight paintings of the early modern moment in Paris, assembled by a working-class dealer who died at forty-two and shaped over forty years by his widow Domenica.

This tour walks you through both. The Water Lilies first, slowly. Then downstairs through Renoir, Cézanne, Rousseau, Picasso, Matisse, Modigliani, Soutine, and the quieter voices around them. Then back up to the lilies, for one more visit, before walking out into the Tuileries and the rest of Paris.

Take your time. The paintings will not get faster. Neither should we.

How to Use This Tour

What to bring, what to skip, what to do with the bench in the middle of the room.

Walk in order, the first time.

The thirty tracks tell a single story. We arrive at the building, walk through the Water Lilies once, go downstairs to meet the Walter-Guillaume collection, then come back up to the lilies for a second, slower look. The return visit is the heart of the tour. Skipping it skips most of what we built.

Use the Stop & Look box to find your spot.

Every track starts with a Stop & Look box: where to stand, what you'll see, what to listen for. If you're disoriented or arrive at a track late, the box gets you back to the right wall in under a minute.

Trust the heavy tracks.

Four tracks are marked ★★ HEAVY — Monet's life behind the lilies, Modigliani, Soutine, and the closing meditation. These move slowly. They handle grief, illness, war. Take them seriously. Sit down if a bench is free.

The light in the lily rooms shifts hour by hour.

The Water Lilies are lit only by daylight, by Monet's own design. The compositions you see at 10 a.m. are not the compositions you see at 4 p.m. The second visit, near the end of the tour, will reward you with a different version of the same paintings — if any time has passed.

It's okay to pause between tracks.

We don't move at a fixed pace. If you want to stand in front of one painting for ten extra minutes, that's the right thing to do. The tour will wait.

Contents

Walk in order, or jump to any track. Times are approximate.

PART I — ARRIVAL & THE BUILDING

- | | |
|--|------|
| 01. Welcome — The Orangery in the Garden | 3:00 |
| 02. The Glass Wall & the Stone Wall | 3:00 |
| 03. From Citrus Trees to Monet ★ | 4:00 |

PART II — THE WATER LILIES, FIRST PASS

- | | |
|---|------|
| 04. Stepping Into the First Oval Room — How to Look ★ | 4:00 |
| 05. Morning — The Eastern Composition ★ | 4:00 |
| 06. Setting Sun — Where Light Becomes Fire ★ | 4:00 |
| 07. Clouds — Reflection as Sky | 3:00 |
| 08. Green Reflections — The Quiet Composition | 3:00 |
| 09. Passing Through to the Second Oval Room | 2:30 |
| 10. The Two Willows & Morning with Willows ★ | 4:30 |
| 11. Tree Reflections & Clear Morning with Willows ★ | 4:00 |

PART III — MONET, THE MAN

- | | |
|--|------|
| 12. Giverny, the War, the Cataracts ★★ | 4:30 |
|--|------|

PART IV — WALTER-GUILLAUME COLLECTION

- | | |
|---|------|
| 13. Going Downstairs — Paul Guillaume & Domenica Walter ★ | 4:00 |
| 14. Renoir — Yvonne and Christine Lerolle at the Piano ★ | 4:00 |
| 15. Cézanne — The Portraits & Still Lives ★ | 4:00 |
| 16. Le Rocher Rouge — The Landscape That Changed Painting | 3:00 |
| 17. Henri Rousseau — The Wedding & Father Junier's Cart ★ | 4:00 |
| 18. Rousseau's Jungles — The Snake Charmer & The Customs Officer | 3:00 |
| 19. Rousseau's Ambition — What 'The Ambition of Painting' Means ★ | 4:00 |
| 20. Picasso — Twelve Works, Two Periods ★ | 4:00 |
| 21. The Embrace & Large Bather | 3:00 |
| 22. Matisse — The Three Sisters Triptych ★ | 4:00 |
| 23. Modigliani — Five Portraits, One Long Loneliness ★★ | 4:30 |
| 24. Soutine — The Pastry Cook, Page Boy, Carcass of Beef ★★ | 4:30 |
| 25. Derain, Laurencin & Utrillo — The Quieter Voices | 3:00 |

PART V — RETURN TO THE WATER LILIES

- | | |
|--|------|
| 26. Coming Back Up — The Second Visit | 3:00 |
| 27. What Monet Built Here — The Oval Rooms as Architecture ★ | 4:00 |
| 28. Sitting in the Silence — One Last Look ★★ | 4:30 |

PART VI — CLOSING

29. Walking Out — The Tuileries, the Concorde, the Seine	3:00
30. Practical Info & Goodbye	2:30

PART I — ARRIVAL & THE BUILDING

Three tracks. The orangery, the wall of glass, the donation that made the museum.

Welcome — The Orangery in the Garden

Standing at the entrance, on the Seine side of the Tuileries

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

At the museum entrance, on the western edge of the Jardin des Tuileries, near the Place de la Concorde.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

A long, low building with one solid wall facing you and a wall of glass on the Seine side. Stone, light, gravel underfoot.

LISTEN FOR

Why this building is shaped the way it is — and what it was holding before it held Monet's paintings.

So — here we are. Take a breath.

You're standing at the western corner of the Jardin des Tuileries, with the Place de la Concorde a few minutes behind you and the Seine just over the parapet to your right. The building in front of you is long and low — almost too modest, given what's inside. It's the Musée de l'Orangerie.

Before we step in, let me tell you what we're walking into. This is one of the smallest major museums in Paris. You can see it all in about an hour and a half. But it has, on the ground floor, two oval rooms — designed by Claude Monet himself — that hold eight large compositions of water lilies. Twenty-two panels of canvas in total, joined together into eight uninterrupted views of his pond at Giverny. And on the lower level, it has a private collection of modern art that an early-twentieth-century dealer named Paul Guillaume put together between 1914 and 1934. After he died young — at forty-two — his widow Domenica and her second husband, the architect Jean Walter, expanded and reshaped it. The French state bought it from her in the late 1950s. Today, it's a hundred and forty-eight paintings: Renoir, Cézanne, Picasso, Matisse, Modigliani, Soutine, Rousseau, Derain. A small, very dense, very personal collection of the early modern moment in Paris.

That's the museum. The Water Lilies — the Nymphéas — and the Walter-Guillaume collection. Two rooms upstairs, a longer route downstairs.

Here's what I want to suggest for the way we walk through it. Most visitors come in, spend ten minutes in the Water Lilies rooms, and move on. I'd like us to do something different. We'll go into the lilies first, slowly, panel by panel. Then we'll go downstairs and meet the Walter-Guillaume collection. And then — and this is the part most people skip — we'll come back up to the Water Lilies and sit with them one more time. Because everything you see downstairs changes what those lilies feel like. Monet painted them as a gift to France after the First World War, a "haven for peaceful meditation," in his own words. And meditation isn't something you do once, in a hurry.

A few practical things before we move. The museum is open every day except Tuesdays, nine to six. The Water Lilies rooms have natural skylights — the light shifts as the sky shifts, which is exactly how Monet wanted it. So if it's a bright day, those rooms will look one way; if it's overcast, they'll look another. There's

no wrong day to come.

If you've already got your ticket — good. Let's go in.

The Glass Wall & the Stone Wall

Why this building is shaped the way it is

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Just inside the entrance, or pause again outside if you can see the south facade.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

Two long walls, deliberately unequal. South: glass, sun, the Seine. North: solid stone, no windows.

LISTEN FOR

How a building made to keep oranges warm in winter turned out to be perfect for holding light.

Look at the building.

It's a long rectangle, and the two long walls are not the same. The one facing the Seine — south — is glass. The one facing the gardens — north — is almost entirely solid stone. No windows. Nothing.

That asymmetry is the whole story of this place.

The Orangerie was built in 1852, on the orders of Napoleon III, to do exactly what its name says: shelter the orange trees that grew in pots in the Tuileries Garden. Orange trees can't survive a Paris winter. So every autumn, the gardeners wheeled them in, and every spring they wheeled them back out. The architect was a man named Firmin Bourgeois — he died the year after it was completed, so the entrance facades were finished by Louis Visconti, who was working on the Louvre at the same time. If you look closely at the carved decoration above the doorways, you'll see ears of corn, cornucopias, plants — the iconography of a working greenhouse.

The glass wall faces south to catch the winter sun. The stone wall faces north to block the cold winds. That's just sensible greenhouse design. The trees needed light, and they needed shelter, and the building gave them both.

Now — here's the part that matters. In 1921, three years after the end of the First World War, the French state was looking for somewhere to display the Water Lilies that Monet was promising to donate. The painter had originally imagined them at the Musée Rodin, in another building entirely. But Georges Clemenceau — the wartime prime minister, who was also Monet's closest friend — pushed for them to come here. To the Orangerie.

Why? Because Monet wanted the paintings lit by natural daylight. Not electric light. Not gallery spots. The light of the sky, coming down from above, shifting through the day. And this building — this old greenhouse for orange trees, with its long glass wall and its tradition of being a place where sunlight could be trusted — was already built for that. They added skylights to the roof. They built two oval rooms inside. And the same architecture that had been designed to keep citrus trees alive turned out to be the right architecture for holding eight panels of pondwater.

So when we go in, remember: this building wasn't designed for the paintings. The paintings found the building.

From Citrus Trees to Monet

How the Orangerie became a museum

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Inside the entrance lobby, near the introductory wall panels.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

A small, calm vestibule. The Water Lilies rooms are just ahead. The Walter-Guillaume collection is downstairs.

LISTEN FOR

A hundred and twenty years of small decisions — a war, a friendship, a contract signed two days after the Armistice.

Let's walk through how this place actually became what it is. There are a few dates worth holding in your head.

Eighteen-fifty-two: built as an orangery, as we just talked about. For the next sixty years, it lived a quiet life — winter shelter for trees, summer venue for the occasional concert, dog show, or art exhibition. Nothing remarkable. The Empire fell in 1870. The Tuileries Palace next door burned in 1871. The Orangerie survived. The state took it over in 1921 and gave it to the Under-Secretariat of State for Fine Arts, with the idea of using it as exhibition space for living artists.

And then comes Claude Monet.

Monet was eighty-one years old in 1921, living at Giverny in the Normandy countryside. For almost twenty years, he had been painting his pond — water lilies, willows, the surface of water, the sky reflected in it — over and over again. After the outbreak of the First World War, those paintings had grown enormous. He was building rooms in his garden specifically to paint in: a third studio with skylights, big enough to hold canvases nearly seven feet tall and, in some cases, more than fifty feet long.

On November twelfth, 1918 — the day after the Armistice that ended the war — Monet wrote a letter to Clemenceau. He said: "I'm about to finish two decorative panels which I want to sign on the day of victory, and ask you to offer to the State." He wanted to give them as a monument to peace.

That offer eventually grew. Monet ended up committing not two panels but eight compositions — twenty-two canvas sections in all, joined together so the seams disappear. The donation contract was signed in 1922. And he and the architect Camille Lefèvre worked out the design together — two oval rooms, side by side, the panels mounted directly onto the walls. The floor plan, from above, looks like the symbol for infinity. Two ovals, meeting at a single point.

Now — Monet didn't actually want to give them up. He kept working on them until the very end of his life, refusing to part with them. He died on December fifth, 1926, at Giverny. The panels were finally installed at the Orangerie a few months later, and the museum opened to the public in May 1927.

The Walter-Guillaume collection came much later — purchased by the state in 1959 and 1963, displayed permanently from 1984. That collection lives downstairs. The Water Lilies live up here, on the ground floor.

What this means in practice: you're about to walk into a space that was designed by a painter, for paintings he didn't want to give away, in a building originally meant for orange trees, lit by the same Paris sky that lit his pond at Giverny. Everything you're about to see has a reason it's where it is.

The first oval room is just through that door.

PART II — THE WATER LILIES, FIRST PASS

Eight tracks. The two oval rooms, taken slowly, in the order Monet designed.

Stepping Into the First Oval Room — How to Look

Before any single painting — how to be in the space

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Just inside the first oval room. Stand near the center if you can.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

Four enormous curved panels of water lilies, mounted continuously around an oval. Daylight from a skylight overhead.

LISTEN FOR

How to slow your eyes down. What Monet was actually trying to do here.

Step in. Take your time at the threshold.

Notice, first, the quiet. The oval shape softens sound — there are no flat corners for footsteps and conversation to bounce off. Notice the light. It's coming from a skylight in the ceiling, filtered by a stretched fabric scrim that diffuses it. There's no electric spotlighting on the paintings. The light you're standing in is the light that's outside right now, just gentled.

Now look at the walls. There are four large compositions in this first room — Setting Sun, Clouds, Green Reflections, and Morning. They wrap around you in a continuous oval — no breaks at the corners, because there are no corners. Together they're made of ten separate canvas sections, joined so seamlessly you'd never know unless you went looking for the seams. Each composition is two meters tall — about six and a half feet — and the longest two stretch more than twelve and a half meters across. They were mounted directly onto the curved walls when the museum opened in 1927, and they haven't moved since.

The four compositions are oriented to the four points of the compass. Setting Sun, as you'd expect from its title, faces west. Morning faces east. The other two — Clouds and Green Reflections — fill the north and south arcs. The whole room is, in that sense, a kind of clock made out of light.

Before we look at any one panel — let me tell you what Monet was trying to do here.

In 1909, he gave an interview to a critic named Roger Marx. He had just finished a series of forty-eight water-lily paintings, but he was already imagining something larger. He said — and this is the line on the cover of this tour — that he wanted to create "the illusion of an endless whole, of a wave without horizon and without shore." A room with no edges. A surface of water that would surround the viewer entirely. He talked about nerves overstrained by work being able to rest here, "like a flower-filled aquarium." Those were his exact words. A space designed to dissolve the boundary between you and the painting.

So here's what I'd like you to do. Don't read the panels like books. Don't look for objects. There are water lilies, yes — but there's no horizon line, no shoreline, no fixed point of view. Monet painted these from a small boat on his pond at Giverny, looking down at the surface of the water. Every panel is a view straight down. What you're seeing is the surface of a pond — with the sky reflected in it, and the trees and willows above, and the lily pads floating on top of all of that, layered into each other.

The eye can't decide what's up and what's down. That's the point.

Walk slowly around the room. Don't try to take it all in at once. Stop at one composition. Look. Move on. The paintings will not get faster.

We're going to take them in the order Monet designed for them — starting with **Morning**, on the eastern wall, because the cycle of these rooms moves with the sun.

Morning — The Eastern Composition

Matin, c. 1914–1926

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Stand in front of the long composition on the eastern wall of the first oval room.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

A composition of three joined panels, almost forty-two feet across. Pale blues, soft greens. Water lilies floating on a pond at first light.

LISTEN FOR

How Monet uses willow leaves at the edges to frame the surface — and why he removed every reference point in the middle.

This is Morning. *Matin*, in French.

It's the longest composition in the first room — three panels joined together, two meters tall and twelve and three-quarter meters across. About forty-two feet, end to end. Stand back a little if you can. Try to see it as a whole before you walk along its length.

Look at the colors first. Cool blues. Pale lavender. A wash of soft green at the surface where the lily pads gather. There's no sun in this picture. There's no warmth. This is the pond at Giverny in the very early morning — before the day has decided what it's going to be.

Now look at what's actually painted, and what isn't.

At the far left edge, you'll see willow branches — narrow leaves hanging down into the picture. They drop from the top of the canvas like a curtain at the edge of your peripheral vision. At the far right, the same thing happens. Willow leaves enter from outside the frame. Between them, in the middle of the composition, there's almost nothing solid. No shoreline. No bank. No horizon. The eye has nowhere to land except on the lily pads themselves — small ovals of green, drifting in clusters, and the reflections of trees and sky on the water beneath them.

Monet did something radical here. By the time he started painting these large panels, around 1914, he had been painting his pond for nearly twenty years. He had already painted hundreds of versions of it. What he did differently in the *Nymphéas* was that he removed the bank. He cropped the world. He left only the surface of the water, the floating lilies, and what's reflected in the surface from above. The picture has no up and no down. It's a kind of disorientation by design.

Here's what to do with that. Look at the lily pads. Then look at what's behind them — the reflections. Then ask yourself which is which. The lily pads sit on top of the water. The reflections are below the water. But because there's no horizon, both of those things occupy the same picture plane. The pads and the reflected sky are in the same place. Your brain has to choose which it's looking at, moment by moment.

This is, by the way, one of the reasons abstract painters of the nineteen-fifties — Jackson Pollock, Joan Mitchell, Ellsworth Kelly — kept coming back to these rooms. Monet got to the dissolution of the picture

plane fifty years before they did. He just kept calling them water lilies.

One last thing. Look closely at the brushwork. Step right up to the canvas. You'll see that Monet painted in short, broken strokes — flecks of pigment, dragged and overlapped. From three meters back, those flecks become reflections. From thirty centimeters away, they become what they actually are: paint. Pure paint, in dozens of layered colors.

Hold this view for a minute. We'll walk to Setting Sun next, on the opposite wall.

Setting Sun — Where Light Becomes Fire

Soleil couchant, c. 1914–1926

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Cross to the opposite wall of the first oval room — the western arc.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

The smallest of the four compositions in this room. A single panel, two meters by six. Reds, oranges, deep golds. The pond at dusk.

LISTEN FOR

Why this panel is the warmest in the room — and what the debate about Monet's eyesight has to do with it.

Now turn around. Walk to the opposite wall.

This is Setting Sun. *Soleil couchant*. It's the smallest of the four compositions in this room — a single panel of canvas, two meters by six. That's about nineteen and a half feet across. After Morning, it'll feel almost intimate.

But look at the colors.

This is the warmest painting in the whole Orangerie. Deep reds. Burnt orange. Gold that almost glows. The reflections in the water are no longer cool blue — they're embers. The lily pads, which a moment ago were soft pale green, are now caught in reflected fire. This is the pond at Giverny at the end of the day, when the western sky is on its way down and the water remembers it.

Notice the orientation. This composition faces west — the actual western direction, by compass — and the architect Camille Lefèvre and Monet planned that on purpose. So Setting Sun is on the west wall. Morning is on the east. The two ends of the day, lined up with the two ends of the world.

Now here's a question that art historians have argued about for over a century. Look at how saturated these reds are. Look at the orange. Some scholars have suggested that the warmth in this composition reflects Monet's failing eyesight. By the early nineteen-twenties, Monet had advanced cataracts in both eyes. Cataracts shift color perception toward yellow and red — they pull the cooler tones out of what you see. After his cataract operation in 1923, on his right eye, Monet looked at some of the canvases he'd painted in the years before and said they looked too red. He repainted some. He destroyed others.

So — is Setting Sun a painting of dusk, or a painting of dusk seen through cataracts, or both? Probably both. We can't pull them apart. Monet was eighty years old when he was working on these. He'd lost his wife Alice in 1911. He'd lost his oldest son Jean in 1914. The First World War was happening, on French soil, only forty miles from his garden. His eyes were failing. And he kept painting. Whatever those reds are, they're the reds of a man working through everything at once.

There's no neat answer to give you about that. Just stand in front of it. The painting is here. The reds are here. You're seeing what he saw — filtered through whatever he saw it with.

When you're ready, look to the long wall on your left or right. The next composition is Clouds.

Clouds — Reflection as Sky

Les Nuages, c. 1914–1926

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Move to the long wall holding Clouds — a three-panel composition almost the length of Morning.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

Three joined panels, about forty-two feet wide. The pond surface, but with cloud reflections sliding across it. Pale pinks, lavenders, slate blues.

LISTEN FOR

Where the sky is in this painting — and the trick that makes you forget which way is up.

This is Clouds. Les Nuages.

Same length as Morning — three panels joined, twelve and three-quarter meters across. But the mood is different. The colors are paler. There's more white. More lavender. More of that almost-pink that you get in Paris skies in the late afternoon, when the day is still soft but the sun is no longer high.

Now, look at the painting and ask yourself a question. Where is the sky in this picture?

Walk along it slowly. You'll find clouds — clearly clouds, white and grey and shifting — distributed across the canvas. But there's no horizon. There's no upward direction. The clouds aren't above. They're inside the surface of the water. What you're looking at is the reflection of the sky in the pond, and Monet has cropped out every other reference point so completely that the reflection has become the thing itself.

This is the trick of all the Nymphéas, but it's clearest here. Monet didn't paint clouds. He painted the surface of a pond in which clouds happened to be visible. The water is the painting. The sky is what's inside the water.

Look at the lily pads. They sit on top of those clouds — physically on top, since they float on the actual water — but visually, they look like they're hovering in the sky. The painting won't tell you which is right. Both are right.

This is, I think, why people come back to this room over and over. You can never quite settle the image. Every time you stand in front of it, the relationship between the lilies and the reflections shifts. Your brain keeps trying to decide. The painting keeps refusing.

There's a quiet joke embedded in the title, too. Nuages — clouds — is what we'd usually call the subject of a sky painting. But this isn't a sky painting. There's no sky here. There's only water and what water remembers.

Stand here for as long as you want. We'll move to Green Reflections next.

Green Reflections — The Quiet Composition

Reflets verts, c. 1914–1926

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Walk to the last of the four compositions — Green Reflections, on the opposite long wall from Clouds.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

Two panels joined together, about twenty-eight feet wide. Deep greens, blue-greens, dark water. The most contemplative composition in this room.

LISTEN FOR

Why this is often the panel visitors stop the longest in front of — and what it might be doing to your nervous system.

Last composition in this room. Green Reflections — Reflets verts.

Two panels joined together, two meters tall and eight and a half meters across. So shorter than Morning and Clouds — about twenty-eight feet — but still substantial. After the warm reds of Setting Sun and the pale pinks of Clouds, this one will feel like cool water.

Stand in front of it. Let your eyes adjust.

The dominant color is green. Not bright green — not the green of spring leaves. This is the green of deep water, of moss seen through shadow, of willow leaves reflected on a still surface. It's the green you get when light has had to travel through layers of water and leaf before reaching your eye. Where the other compositions in this room use blue or pink or red as their main note, this one stays in the cool middle of the spectrum and never leaves.

Look at the water lilies here. They're scattered across the surface in small floating clusters. They're not the subject. They're not even particularly emphasized. They're more like punctuation — small marks of pink and white and pale yellow that interrupt the green long enough for your eye to find a place to rest.

Now here's something I want to point out about what happens to you when you look at this painting. Monet said, in the 1909 interview with Roger Marx — the one the cover quote is from — that he wanted these rooms to provide "an asylum of peaceful meditation in the middle of a flower-filled aquarium." His exact words. He was specifically thinking about people with nerves worn out by work. He wanted the room to slow you down.

And there's evidence it actually does that. The eyes have to keep adjusting between the lily pads and the reflections beneath them. There's nowhere to focus for long. The painting refuses to resolve. And while your eyes are doing that — while they're constantly making and unmaking a stable image — something in the rest of your body slows down. Your breathing changes. You stop scrolling, mentally. You stop reaching for the next thing.

That's not mystical. It's just what happens when a painting doesn't let your visual attention settle.

So stand here. Don't read the painting. Don't analyze it. Just keep looking at it, and let your eyes find their own way through it.

When you're ready, we'll walk through to the second oval room. Take your time getting there.

Passing Through to the Second Oval Room

The narrow corridor between the two infinity ovals

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Walk through the short connecting passage between the two oval rooms.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

A short corridor. Quieter than the rooms. The architecture asks you to pause for a few seconds before re-entering the lilies.

LISTEN FOR

Why this connecting space matters — and what the second room is going to do that the first one didn't.

Walk through. Don't rush it.

This connecting space — the narrow passage between the two oval rooms — is doing real work. Monet and his architect Camille Lefèvre designed the two rooms to read like the two halves of the infinity symbol. The passage you're walking through right now is the single point where the two ovals touch. Mathematically, it has no width. Architecturally, it's a few steps of plaster. But what it does to your experience is force a small reset before the next room begins.

It also means something about the order of the paintings. In the first room, you were watching the cycle of a day — Morning on the east wall, Setting Sun on the west, Clouds and Green Reflections filling the cardinal arcs in between. The compositions in that room are about light hours and time of day.

The second room is different. The compositions there are about willows. About reflections of trees. About the deep water under the surface. If the first room is the open pond at the four hours of the day, the second room is the same pond, but looking inward — toward the trees on the bank, toward what's submerged, toward what's in shadow.

A second thing worth knowing. The second room is slightly larger than the first, and it holds twelve panels rather than ten — though the compositions still number four. Some of the canvases in there are the largest single paintings Monet ever made. The longest composition stretches over seventeen meters. Almost fifty-six feet.

Step in when you're ready. Stand near the center of the room for a moment. Let the new space surround you before you walk to any one painting.

The Two Willows & Morning with Willows

Les Deux Saules · Le Matin aux saules — the long wall

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Stand in front of the longest composition in the second oval room — The Two Willows, the centerpiece.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

An enormous painting, more than fifty feet across, of two willow trunks descending into the water at either end. Beside it, another long composition with willow leaves spilling in from the top.

LISTEN FOR

How willows act as anchors in a world Monet otherwise emptied. And what those trunks were doing in his garden.

This is The Two Willows — Les Deux Saules. The longest composition in the whole Orangerie. Four canvas panels joined end to end, two meters tall and over seventeen meters across. Almost fifty-six feet.

Stand back. Try to take in the whole length of it before you move. You almost can't, even from the center of the room. The painting is bigger than your field of vision.

Now — here's what's different about this composition. At the far left, you'll see a willow trunk descending straight down into the water. At the far right, another willow trunk does the same thing. Two vertical lines, anchoring the painting at both ends. Everything between them — water, lily pads, reflections, sky-on-water — flows uninterrupted from one trunk to the other.

In every other Nymphéas composition, Monet removed every reference point. Here, he gave you two. Why?

Because Monet's willows weren't decoration. They were the actual willows on the actual banks of his pond at Giverny — trees he had planted himself and tended for thirty years. He once said that if he hadn't become a painter, he would have become a gardener. The pond at Giverny was something he had built — diverted from a branch of the river Epte in 1893, with permission from the local authorities, and stocked with water lilies he ordered from a specialist nursery. The willows around it were grown specifically to drop their leaves into the water. The Japanese bridge that crossed it was inspired by prints he had been collecting since the eighteen-seventies.

So in The Two Willows, those trunks are not symbolic. They're literal. They're the actual willows that stood at the actual ends of the actual pond. And by including them, Monet is grounding the painting — telling you that even in this infinite-feeling surface of water, there are real places on a real bank, with real trees holding up real sky.

Now look just to the right — or left, depending on where you're standing — at the next composition. This one is Morning with Willows. Le Matin aux saules. Same length almost — three panels, twelve and three-quarter meters across. But here the willow trunks aren't on the picture. Instead, the willow leaves themselves enter from above. Long thin leaves, like a curtain, descending into the painting from the top edge.

You're seeing the same trees, but from a different position on the pond. In one composition Monet rowed close to the willow trunks. In the other, he was beneath them — looking up through the leaves at the water.

These two compositions are siblings. They were probably painted around the same time, between roughly 1920 and 1926, in the third studio Monet had built specifically for them at Giverny. That studio had north-facing skylights, just like this room. He could work on canvases this size only because he had designed the building to make it possible.

Walk along *The Two Willows* from left to right. Stop at the willow trunk on each end. Spend a moment with each. Those are the two ends of his world.

Tree Reflections & Clear Morning with Willows

Reflets d'arbres · Le Matin clair aux saules — closing the loop

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Turn to the remaining two compositions in the second oval room.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

Tree Reflections, the darkest composition in either room. And Clear Morning with Willows, which lifts the mood by a few degrees of light.

LISTEN FOR

What's submerged in these paintings, and why Monet finished his life painting reflections rather than the things being reflected.

Two more compositions to go in this room.

Look first at Tree Reflections — *Reflets d'arbres*. This is the darkest painting in either oval room. Deep greens, near-blacks, slate-blues, the occasional pale punctuation of a lily pad. There's no light source in it. There's no sky visible. What you're looking at is the water in shadow, with the entire mass of the willow trees above visible only as their reflection in the surface.

Notice what Monet has done. The trees themselves are not in this painting. They're not visible. They're outside the frame, above the picture, casting their shapes onto the water. And what we're shown — what he chose to paint — is only the reflection. The original is somewhere off to the side. The image, on the water, is the entire subject.

This is the most extreme version of what the *Nymphéas* project is. In every painting Monet had made before this — every haystack, every cathedral facade, every river view from his earlier years — he had painted the thing itself. A haystack was a haystack. A cathedral was a cathedral. Here, at the end of his life, he's painting only the reflection. The thing is gone. Only the image remains.

If you stand in front of Tree Reflections long enough, the surface starts to feel like a memory. Like a glance backward at things that aren't there anymore.

Now turn to Clear Morning with Willows. *Le Matin clair aux saules*. This composition is the gentlest in the second room — pale blues, soft pinks, willow leaves entering again from the top. The mood is the opposite of Tree Reflections: bright, opening, full of air.

These two paintings, taken together, give you the full emotional range of the second room. Shadowed water on one side. Clear morning light on the other. Both made of reflections, both with the actual subjects somewhere just out of frame.

And if you walk slowly around this whole second oval — Tree Reflections, Morning with Willows, The Two Willows, Clear Morning with Willows — you'll see that the four compositions together form a closed cycle. From dark to light, from submerged to airborne, from the willow as trunk to the willow as leaves. The room is its own complete poem.

A few visitors get to this point and feel they've seen everything they came to see. They walk out. They never go downstairs. I want to suggest that this would be a mistake. Because Paul Guillaume — the dealer who built the collection below us — was thirteen years old when Monet started painting these lilies. By the time these panels were installed in this room in 1927, Guillaume had been the most aggressive young dealer of modern art in Paris for nearly a decade. He was buying Picasso, Modigliani, Soutine, Rousseau, Derain — all alive, all working, all changing what painting could be.

The Water Lilies are the end of one tradition. What's downstairs is the beginning of another. And we can't understand one without seeing the other.

So we'll take one more breath here, in the second oval. And then we'll go down.

PART III — MONET, THE MAN

One heavy track. The painter behind the paintings — what he was carrying.

Giverny, the War, the Cataracts

How these paintings were actually made

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Find a bench in the second oval room, or stand quietly near a corner of the corridor.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

Whichever Nymphéas panel is closest to where you've sat down. Look at it while we talk.

LISTEN FOR

What Monet was carrying when he made these paintings — his wife, his son, the war forty miles away, and his own failing eyes.

Sit down if you can.

I want to talk about who made these paintings, and how. Because the rooms you're sitting in are beautiful, and the paintings are beautiful, and it's easy to forget that they came out of one of the hardest stretches of an old man's life.

Claude Monet was born in 1840. He moved to Giverny — the village in Normandy where he built the pond and the gardens these paintings come from — in 1883. He was forty-three. He spent the next forty-three years there, until he died in December 1926.

The Water Lilies — these specific compositions, the ones around you — were made mostly between 1914 and 1926. Twelve years. The last twelve years of his life. Which means I have to tell you about three things that were happening while he painted them.

The first thing is his wife. Alice Monet, his second wife, died in May 1911. She was sixty-six. Monet had loved her for thirty years. After her death, he stopped painting almost entirely for nearly two years. The letters he wrote in that period are heartbreaking. He said he couldn't see anything. He said the world had gone flat. When he finally started working again, he started on these lilies.

The second thing is the war. The First World War began in August 1914. Giverny is about forty miles from the front line at its closest. Monet could hear artillery from his garden. His older son Jean was already ill — he died in February 1914, six months before the war began, at the age of forty-six. The younger son Michel went to fight. Monet's stepson Jean-Pierre also went. The village around Giverny emptied of young men. For four years, while Monet was painting these enormous serene panels of his pond, France was being torn apart at the other end of the same train line.

And here's the thing. The Water Lilies are not about that war. There are no soldiers in them. No trenches. No tanks. They are paintings of a private garden, of a private pond, of one man's attempt to keep painting water lilies while the world was on fire. And that fact — the fact that he kept painting them anyway — is what made them, in his mind, a memorial. The day after the Armistice, in November 1918, Monet wrote to Clemenceau and said he was ready to donate the panels to France. He called them — and this is his phrasing — "a monument to peace."

These paintings exist because of the war. Not in spite of it.

The third thing is his eyes. Around 1908, Monet started noticing his vision changing. By 1912, he was diagnosed with cataracts in both eyes. Cataracts shift color toward yellow and red — they pull the blue out of the world. By the early nineteen-twenties, Monet was nearly blind. He could only see by holding his face inches from the canvas. He had trouble distinguishing colors at all. He had his right eye operated on in January 1923, at age eighty-two. The surgery was difficult. Afterward, some of the canvases he'd painted in the previous years looked, to his recovered eye, too red. He destroyed several. He repainted others.

So everything you're seeing in these rooms was made by an old man who had lost his wife, was hearing artillery from his garden, and was nearly blind for the last five years of the work. He didn't stop. He kept painting. He died on December fifth, 1926, with the panels finally finished and waiting to be installed.

The Orangerie opened with them in May 1927. Five months after his death. He never saw them in this room.

Take a breath. We'll go downstairs in a minute.

PART IV — WALTER-GUILLAUME COLLECTION

Thirteen tracks. The downstairs rooms. Renoir, Cézanne, Rousseau, Picasso, Matisse, Modigliani, Soutine, and the quieter voices.

Going Downstairs — Paul Guillaume & Domenica Walter

Who built the collection you're about to walk through

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Take the staircase or elevator to the lower level. Pause at the entrance to the first room.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

A more conventional set of gallery rooms, opening off a corridor. Each room dedicated to one or two artists.

LISTEN FOR

How a working-class kid from a Paris suburb became one of the most important dealers in modern art before he died at forty-two.

Now we're going to walk through a collection that almost didn't exist. So before we look at any specific painting, let me tell you who built it.

Paul Guillaume was born in 1891, in a working-class neighborhood in Paris. He left school early. He found work as a stock boy in a tire factory. And in his late teens, somewhere around 1908 or 1909, he started picking up African and Oceanian objects — masks, statues — from the dockworkers who handled goods coming in from the French colonies. He sold them out of a little shop. He was completely self-taught.

In 1911, the poet Guillaume Apollinaire — yes, Apollinaire was his first name; Paul Guillaume was his surname — Apollinaire spotted this twenty-year-old in the African-art trade and introduced him to the avant-garde art world. To Picasso, Modigliani, Soutine, Derain. To the painters Apollinaire was writing about in the magazines.

Guillaume opened his first gallery in 1914. He was twenty-three. Over the next twenty years, he became one of the most important dealers in modern art in Europe. He bought Modigliani when nobody wanted Modigliani. He bought Soutine when Soutine was painting in a basement, alone, starving. He bought Henri Rousseau — the customs officer who painted on weekends — at a moment when most critics thought Rousseau was a joke. He held the famous 1918 "face-to-face" exhibition that paired Matisse and Picasso in the same gallery. He acquired around fifty Rousseaus over his career. He owned hundreds of paintings by the time he died.

And then, in 1934, at the age of forty-two, Paul Guillaume died. Suddenly. He had been planning, in his last years, to open his collection as the first French museum of modern art. He didn't get there.

His widow, Domenica, was twenty years younger than him. She was thirty-six when he died. Four years later, in 1938, she married a man named Jean Walter — an architect and industrialist, twenty years older than her, who had made a fortune in mining. She kept her late husband's collection but transformed it heavily. She sold over two hundred paintings — including all the de Chiricos, many of the Modiglianis, all of Picasso's Cubist works, and every single piece of African art Paul had collected. In their place, she bought more Renoirs and Cézannes, which she preferred. She also kept the things she liked most about her first husband's taste: the Rousseaus, the Soutines, some of the Matisses, the late Picassos.

Jean Walter died in 1957. Two years later, in 1959, the French state bought the first part of the collection from Domenica. The second part was purchased in 1963. She kept the right to live with the paintings until her own death — which came in 1977. The collection finally went on permanent display here at the Orangerie in 1984. Domenica had asked for it to be named after both of her husbands. So it's the Jean Walter and Paul Guillaume collection.

A hundred and forty-eight paintings. Renoir, Cézanne, Picasso, Matisse, Modigliani, Soutine, Derain, Rousseau, Utrillo, Laurencin, Gauguin, Sisley, Monet, Van Dongen. Built by a self-taught dealer who died at forty-two, kept and reshaped by his widow over the next forty-three years.

These are the rooms. Let's walk through them.

Renoir — Yvonne and Christine Lerolle at the Piano

Plus the late nudes — Domenica Walter's favorite painter

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Walk into the Renoir room. The Walter-Guillaume collection has twenty-five Renoir paintings; this room is the densest concentration.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

Late Renoir — domestic scenes, family portraits, late nudes. The painting at the center is two young women at a piano.

LISTEN FOR

Why Renoir kept this particular painting for himself until he died — and what Domenica Walter saw in him.

This is the Renoir room. There are twenty-five Renoir paintings in the Walter-Guillaume collection — more than any other artist. Domenica Walter loved Renoir. She bought painting after painting of his in the nineteen-thirties and forties. So you're standing in front of her taste, more than Paul Guillaume's.

Let me take you to one painting in particular. Yvonne and Christine Lerolle at the Piano. Yvonne et Christine Lerolle au piano. Painted in 1897. Oil on canvas, seventy-three by ninety-two centimeters.

Find it. Two young women at a piano. One in white, seated, hands on the keys. The other in red, leaning over her shoulder, looking at the music. The light is warm. The room is full of comfortable bourgeois furniture. On the wall behind them, you can make out two paintings — both by Degas — which were actually in the Lerolle family's home.

The story of this painting matters. The Lerolle family was a well-known household of art patrons in Paris in the eighteen-nineties. Henry Lerolle was a painter himself, and a collector. His daughters Yvonne and Christine were close to Renoir. Edgar Degas was their family friend. The two girls would eventually marry Eugène and Louis Rouart, sons of another major patron family — Degas had introduced the two families to each other.

So this painting comes out of a tight little circle of artists and the families who supported them. Renoir made several preparatory drawings before he started this one. He chose a horizontal format — landscape, not portrait — which gives the composition a settled, almost architectural calm. He was particularly fond of Christine, by his own account. And here's the curious detail. This painting was never part of the Lerolle family collection. Renoir kept it. He kept it in his own home for the rest of his life, and only after he died, in 1919, did it leave the studio.

Why? Nobody knows. It's the kind of small mystery that gets glossed over in museum labels. He just didn't sell it.

Decades later, in 1937, Domenica bought it at a public auction, jointly with another dealer named Paul Durand-Ruel. After 1947, she bought Durand-Ruel out and kept the painting entirely. It was one of her favorite Renoirs in the collection. When you stand in front of it, you're looking at a painting Renoir refused to let go of, that ended up in the home of a woman who was building the largest private gallery of his work in

Europe.

Now, the rest of the room. You'll see Gabrielle and Jean — Renoir's son Jean, the future film director, painted as a baby with the family servant. Claude Renoir in Clown Costume — his youngest son in costume. Late nudes — bathers, women drying themselves, fleshy bodies rendered in deep pinks and reds. These are all from Renoir's last twenty years. By this point he had crippling arthritis. He was painting with brushes strapped to his hands because his fingers could no longer hold them. He lived in the south of France, at Cagnes-sur-Mer, surrounded by family and models.

The late Renoir is divisive. Some viewers find it overly sweet, too pink, too domestic. Others find in it a quiet defiance — an old man with ruined hands continuing to make paintings about pleasure, family, music, the human body, while his body itself was failing.

Take a few minutes in this room. The piano picture will be the centerpiece, but look at the late nudes too. There's something honest in them, if you give them time.

Cézanne — The Portraits & Still Lives

Madame Cézanne, apples, biscuits, and the painter Picasso called 'the father of us all'

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Move into the Cézanne room. Fifteen paintings — a substantial section of the collection.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

Portraits of his wife Hortense. Still lifes — apples, biscuits, a milk jug. A small portrait of his son.

LISTEN FOR

What Cézanne was doing differently from everyone around him — and why every twentieth-century painter who came after him kept saying his name.

Now Cézanne. There are fifteen Cézanne paintings in the Walter-Guillaume collection. Most of them were bought by Paul Guillaume in the nineteen-twenties — by then, Cézanne had been dead for nearly twenty years, but his reputation was still climbing. Picasso reportedly called him "the father of us all." Matisse called him "the master of us all." Every painter we're going to see in the rest of the collection — Picasso, Matisse, Modigliani, Soutine, Derain — was, in some way, working through Cézanne.

Let me show you a few in this room.

First, the portraits of his wife. Cézanne painted his wife Hortense Fiquet at least twenty-six times over their thirty-year marriage. The Walter-Guillaume collection has at least two of those portraits. Find one — she'll be seated, hands folded, very still, looking somewhere past the viewer. The hands and face are painted with the same care, the same patient stacking of color planes, as the chair she's sitting in. Her body and the chair share the same materiality.

This is the Cézanne secret. He treats every part of the painting with the same weight. A face, a piece of fruit, a wall behind a sitter, a hillside — all of them get the same kind of attention, built up out of small, deliberate strokes of color laid next to each other. He doesn't model with light and shadow the way the Renaissance did. He models with planes of color set side by side, each one slightly different, building toward the form.

Now move to the still lifes. The collection includes works like *Apples and Biscuits*, *Fruit, Serviette and Milk Jug*, and *Vase, Sugar Bowl and Apples*. Look at one of them. Find the apples in particular. They're not soft. They don't have the glossy roundness of Dutch still life. They're built out of facets — small flat planes of red and orange and brown and green, each plane a slightly different color, butted up against each other. The apple is a thing made of light and color, more than a thing made of skin and flesh.

And here's why this matters historically. Twelve years after Cézanne's death in 1906, Picasso and Braque invented Cubism. And Cubism — which broke objects into facets, which showed multiple viewpoints at once, which treated form as a thing built up out of geometric planes — Cubism is, in many ways, Cézanne's still lifes turned up to maximum. Picasso said so himself. He said the only painter he had ever followed was Cézanne.

So when you look at these portraits and still lifes — paintings that might look modest, almost amateur in their stillness — you're looking at the source code of twentieth-century painting. Everything that fractures, everything that abstracts, everything that breaks the picture plane apart over the next eighty years is in some way responding to what Cézanne did first, here, with his wife and a bowl of fruit.

A note. From early 2025 through January 2026, the Cézannes from this collection traveled on loan to Japan, for a major exhibition there. So if you visited the Orangerie during that period, the room you're standing in was nearly empty. They came back at the start of this year. If a particular painting I've mentioned isn't on the wall today, the rehang may have shifted things — but the collection itself is whole.

Stay in the room. Walk slowly. The Cézannes reward time.

One more Cézanne to look at, in the next track.

Le Rocher Rouge — The Landscape That Changed Painting

Cézanne, c. 1895, the quarry near Aix-en-Provence

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Find Le Rocher Rouge — The Red Rock — on the wall in the Cézanne room.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

A vertical landscape, ninety-two centimeters tall. Trees in the foreground. An orange-red rock face filling the upper right corner. Blue sky.

LISTEN FOR

How a small painting of a quarry became one of the most influential landscapes ever made.

Find this one. The Red Rock. Le Rocher Rouge. It's a vertical canvas — ninety-two centimeters tall, sixty-eight wide, so about three feet by two. Painted around 1895.

What you're looking at: a stand of trees in the lower half, painted in cross-hatched green brushstrokes. Behind and above them, taking up nearly half the canvas, a great wall of orange-red rock — not painted as a solid shape but built out of planes of color, the same patient layering we just talked about. A strip of blue sky at the top. That's it. That's the whole painting.

This is the Bibémus quarry, just outside Aix-en-Provence in Provence. Cézanne grew up in Aix. He had walked these quarries since he was a boy. In the eighteen-nineties and early nineteen-hundreds, he came back to them again and again — Bibémus is the same set of red rock formations he painted from many angles for the last decade of his life. They're abandoned quarries, where stone had been cut out of the hillside for centuries and then left to weather. The rocks have been exposed to air and rain long enough that they've turned this saturated orange-red.

Why does this small painting matter so much? Look at how Cézanne handles the rock face. It's not modeled with shadow. It's not given depth through perspective. It's a flat plane of color — almost abstract — pushed up against the trees in the foreground. The painting refuses depth in the way you'd expect from a landscape. The rock and the trees occupy almost the same picture plane.

When Georges Braque went to L'Estaque in 1908 — two years after Cézanne died — he started painting landscapes that look directly descended from this one. Houses turned into facets of color. Trees and buildings flattened into the same plane. That work of Braque's, along with what Picasso was doing in the same year, became Cubism.

Apollinaire — the same poet who introduced Paul Guillaume to all the modern painters we're seeing in this collection — wrote about Cézanne in 1910, just four years after his death. He said: "It is known that most new painters lay claim to this sincere and selfless artist." Those are Apollinaire's words. By 1910, every young painter in Paris was already saying Cézanne's name.

Stand in front of this painting for a moment. It's not large. It's not dramatic. But it's one of the small turning points in the history of painting. From here, in the Bibémus quarries, you can draw a line that runs through

Picasso, Braque, Léger, Mondrian, and on through abstraction. Everything that flattens the picture plane in the next forty years is, in some way, on this canvas first.

We have one more big artist in this section: Henri Rousseau. He's in the next room. Let's walk over.

Henri Rousseau — The Wedding & Father Junier's Cart

La Noce, c. 1905 · La Carriole du père Junier, 1908

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Walk into the Rousseau room. Look for The Wedding first — it's a vertical group portrait, more than five feet tall.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

Two paintings: a wedding party arranged like a photograph, with a black dog in front. And a horse-drawn cart carrying a family, a small black dog, and a tiny dog in front of the horse.

LISTEN FOR

Why Rousseau didn't think of himself as 'naïve' — and what he was actually trying to do.

Now we meet Henri Rousseau. The Walter-Guillaume collection has nine Rousseau paintings — Paul Guillaume acquired around fifty of them across his career, and Domenica kept the most important nine. Apollinaire pointed Paul toward Rousseau when Paul was twenty-three years old. The two of them — the dealer and the poet — built up Rousseau's reputation almost together, in the years just after the painter's death in 1910.

Look at The Wedding first. *La Noce*. Painted around 1905. Oil on canvas, about a hundred and sixty-three centimeters tall — over five feet. The vertical orientation matters.

What you see: a wedding party arranged in front of a wall of trees. The bride is in the center, in white, almost ghostly. Around her, the groom and the family members — each face individualized, each person painted with patient attention. At the front, sitting upright and looking directly out at you, is a black dog. The trees behind them recede sharply because each tree gets visibly smaller as it moves up the picture — like a perspective diagram, but more emphatic than any real photograph would render it.

Here's what Rousseau is doing, and why he was misunderstood for most of his life. The figures in this painting are flat. They're silhouettes. They don't model with light and shadow the way an academic painter would. They're presented in a single plane, like figures cut out of paper. And critics in the eighteen-nineties and early nineteen-hundreds laughed at this. They called him primitive. They called him naïve. They thought he couldn't actually paint.

But Rousseau saw himself as a realist. He used that exact word. He said he was painting reality as he saw it. He worked from photographs and postcards — and what he was doing, in part, was treating the painting like a photograph from a studio, where people stand in a row, against a backdrop, with the same flatness photographic figures have. He chose that flatness on purpose. He wasn't failing at depth — he was rejecting it.

Now turn to the second painting. *La Carriole du père Junier*. Father Junier's Cart. Painted in 1908. Smaller and horizontal this time — ninety-seven by a hundred and twenty-nine centimeters.

What you see: a horse-drawn cart with a family in it. The man holding the reins is Claude Junier, a vegetable seller and Rousseau's neighbor. With him are his wife Anna, their niece Léa, a young woman, and — sitting in the cart — Rousseau himself. There's a large black dog at the side. A tiny dog trotting in front of the horse. The horse herself stands on the very tips of her hooves, with shadows beneath, as if she's almost floating off the ground.

There's a story about how this painting came to be. Junier and Rousseau were friends. Rousseau owed Junier money. Junier had just bought a horse he was proud of. They agreed that Rousseau would paint the family in the new cart in lieu of payment. Rousseau worked from a photograph.

But the photograph didn't have a giant black dog. The photograph didn't have a miniature dog trotting in front of the horse. The photograph probably didn't show the horse standing on its tiptoes. Rousseau changed all of these things on purpose. When the painter Max Weber visited him and pointed out that the big black dog was way too large in scale, Rousseau replied that the painting itself demanded the dog be that size.

That's the line that captures Rousseau. The painting demands its own size. He chose every proportion. Nothing is an accident. He was a working-class self-taught painter from outside the art establishment, and what looks like incompetence is, every time, a decision.

We'll look at his jungles next — they're in this same room.

Rousseau's Jungles — The Snake Charmer & The Customs Officer

How a man who never left France painted the most famous jungles in modern art

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Stay in the Rousseau room. Look for the jungle paintings — densely green, with leaves and flowers crowding the picture plane.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

Walls of foliage. Sometimes a figure inside — a woman with a flute, a wild animal, a fruit.

LISTEN FOR

Where Rousseau got his jungles from, and what his real day job was.

The jungle paintings.

Henri Rousseau is famous for jungle scenes. Walls of dense foliage, exotic animals — tigers, monkeys, snakes — in clearings between palm fronds. The strange flatness of those paintings is partly what made his reputation. The most famous of them, *The Snake Charmer*, lives at the Musée d'Orsay. The Walter-Guillaume collection has versions of other jungle works, and you'll find a few in this room. Look for the dense green.

Here's the thing you need to know about Rousseau's jungles. He never saw one. He never went to the tropics. He never left France in his life.

His actual day job — the one that gave him his famous nickname, *Le Douanier*, the customs officer — was as a low-level toll collector at the Paris customs barrier. He inspected wine and produce coming into the city. The job paid badly. He retired in 1893 at the age of forty-nine to paint full-time, but he never made a real living from painting. He was poor for most of his life.

So where did the jungles come from? From three places.

First, the Jardin des Plantes — the botanical gardens in Paris, which had a tropical greenhouse he visited constantly. Second, the natural history museum next to the Jardin des Plantes, where there were stuffed tigers and monkeys. Third, illustrated books and magazines, which he cut up and saved as visual reference. The plants in his jungles are real plants — but they're plants from a glasshouse, painted by a man who walked through the Jardin des Plantes on his lunch breaks.

He took those sources — domestic, accessible, French — and built imaginary landscapes out of them that felt to viewers like dispatches from somewhere else entirely. That's the trick. The jungle paintings are made from material anyone in Paris could have walked over and looked at. Rousseau just looked harder.

Look at how the leaves are painted. Each leaf is drawn carefully, separately, almost as if he traced it from a botany book. There's no atmospheric perspective — no fading into the distance — so every leaf in the foreground has the same crispness as every leaf in the back. The result feels claustrophobic, intricate, dreamlike. The viewer can't see past the leaves.

And remember — this is the year nineteen-oh-five or nineteen-oh-eight. Picasso is in his early twenties, just starting on the work that will become Cubism. Matisse has just shocked the Salon d'Automne in 1905 with the Fauves. Modigliani is still in art school in Italy. While they're all working their way through what painting should do, this fifty-eight-year-old former customs officer is painting careful tigers in fake jungles, and the young modernists keep coming to his studio to look at what he's making.

In November 1908, Picasso and his friends held a famous banquet in Rousseau's honor at the Bateau-Lavoir — the artists' commune in Montmartre. There was a lot of red wine. Apollinaire read a poem. Rousseau played the violin. Some of the guests laughed at him. Others took him seriously. He left thinking he'd been crowned.

He died two years later, in 1910, at sixty-six. Pneumonia. His reputation kept growing after his death. Paul Guillaume bought his work cheaply and held onto it as the price climbed.

Last Rousseau track is next — about what he was actually trying to do.

Rousseau's Ambition — What 'The Ambition of Painting' Means

How a marginal painter became one of the fathers of modernity

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Stand in the middle of the Rousseau room and look at all the works as a group.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

Portraits, urban scenes, the jungle works, the cart, the wedding — different subjects, same hand.

LISTEN FOR

Why the temporary exhibition currently running here is called 'The Ambition of Painting' — and what Rousseau wanted that everyone missed.

There's a temporary exhibition running upstairs in this museum right now — from the spring through the summer of 2026 — titled Henri Rousseau: The Ambition of Painting. If you have time, see it. But even if you don't, let me explain what the title means. It's a phrase worth understanding, because it tells you who Rousseau actually was.

When critics in Rousseau's lifetime called him naïve, they meant it as an insult. They meant he didn't know what he was doing. They meant he was an amateur who happened to produce strange pictures.

Rousseau heard those critics. He responded — not in essays, because he didn't write essays, but in his paintings. The Wedding Party, The Sleeping Gypsy, The Snake Charmer, the late Self-Portrait with Lamp — these are not modest pictures. They're not the works of someone who has lowered his sights. They're huge ambitious compositions, painted by a man who clearly believed he was making the most important art of his time.

Look around this room. Rousseau painted Yvonne and Christine Lerolle? No — that was Renoir, in the other room. But notice the contrast in scale and confidence. Renoir is painting his own friends in their parlor. Rousseau is painting a wedding party larger than life, an exotic jungle no one has seen, a customs officer's daughter posed like a Florentine icon. The subjects are smaller, in social terms, but the ambitions are absolutely not.

That's what the exhibition title is getting at. Rousseau wasn't a naïve painter — he was an ambitious painter who happened to be self-taught. The flatness, the careful patient leaves, the figures arranged like icons — these aren't failures of technique. They're choices made by someone who looked at Italian Renaissance frescoes in books and decided he was going to paint that way, only in modern Paris, only with the materials of a working-class life.

And here's why he became important. In 1907, Picasso bought one of Rousseau's paintings — a portrait of a woman — at a Parisian junk shop for five francs. He kept it for the rest of his life. It hung in every studio Picasso ever lived in, from Montmartre to Mougins. When Picasso looked at Rousseau, he didn't see incompetence. He saw permission. Permission to flatten the picture plane. Permission to paint figures as

silhouettes. Permission to ignore academic perspective and treat the canvas as a flat field where shapes and colors could sit next to each other on their own terms.

Cubism, Fauvism, the early modernism Picasso and Matisse and Braque made between 1905 and 1914 — much of it owes a debt to Rousseau. Not because they copied him, but because he proved you could break the rules of academic painting and produce something that worked.

He never knew how influential he had become. He died in 1910, still poor, while Picasso was selling Cubist paintings for ten times what Rousseau had ever earned. But the artists who came after him knew. And Paul Guillaume, the dealer who built this collection, knew. He bought every Rousseau he could find, when he could find them cheap. Domenica kept the nine you see in this room.

So as you look around — at the wedding, at the cart, at the jungles, at the careful patient leaves — you're looking at the work of a man who refused to be small. That's the ambition of painting. He never lowered it.

Picasso's room is next.

Picasso — Twelve Works, Two Periods

What Paul Guillaume kept and what Domenica Walter sold

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Walk into the Picasso room. Twelve works.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

Picassos from two different periods of his life — the early figurative work, and the 1920s 'return to order' classicism. No Cubism.

LISTEN FOR

Why this Picasso room looks different from a typical Picasso room. And what's been removed.

Twelve Picassos. That's what's here.

But this is going to be a strange Picasso room compared to what you might expect. If you've been to the Musée Picasso across the river, or to MoMA in New York, or to the Tate Modern in London — what you've seen there is Cubism. Fractured forms. Multiple viewpoints on a single face. Brown and grey and tan. That's the Picasso who changed everything between 1907 and 1914.

There is no Cubism in this room.

Why? Because Domenica Walter sold it. When she inherited Paul Guillaume's collection in 1934, it contained Cubist works by Picasso. She didn't like Cubism. So she sold every Cubist Picasso the collection had owned. What's left in this room is, on one side, Picasso's early figurative work — paintings from before he became famous — and on the other side, his later return to classical figuration in the 1920s. Two Picassos. Not the one in the middle.

Let me show you the two sides.

The early work first. Look for the small paintings of bathers, harlequins, and circus performers from the Blue and Rose periods around 1905. The figures are slender, elongated, melancholy. A boy with a flute. A woman seated. A blue-toned mother and child. These are paintings from Picasso's early twenties, when he was a poor immigrant in Paris, painting acrobats and prostitutes and street people. The blues are deep. The figures are quiet. There's almost no movement.

Now move to the later side of the room. Mid-1920s Picasso. He's in his early forties. He's famous. He's been through Cubism, through Surrealism, through every controversy. And he goes back to figuration. Not the figuration of his Blue Period, but a kind of monumental, sculptural classicism. Big bodies. Heavy limbs. Faces that look like Greek statuary. These are sometimes called his "neo-classical" or "return to order" period.

The two sides of this room represent the two parts of Picasso that Paul Guillaume — and Domenica after him — wanted to keep. The young struggling painter, before Cubism. And the established master, after Cubism. The middle part — the Cubist Picasso — is somewhere else. Mostly in private collections in America, mostly bought by Domenica's contemporaries from her in the 1930s and 1940s.

So when you look at the Picasso wall here, you're seeing what a particular kind of collector wanted Picasso to be. Two clean ends of his career. No fracturing.

That tells you something about Domenica. She liked figuration. She liked recognizable bodies. She liked the painter Picasso was at twenty-two and the painter he was at forty-five, but not the painter he was at twenty-six. Her taste shaped what's in this room. Without her, the collection would look very different.

Next track — one or two specific Picassos worth standing in front of.

The Embrace & Large Bather

Picasso, the early 1920s — classicism after Cubism

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

In the Picasso room, find the larger figurative works from the 1920s — heavy bodies, classical poses.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

Two figures embracing. A massive seated bather. Bodies that look like they were carved out of stone.

LISTEN FOR

What 'return to order' meant after the First World War, and why Picasso reached for ancient art when modernism was at its peak.

Find The Embrace — L'Étreinte — in this room. Or Large Bather — Grande Baigneuse — if the rehang has it more prominent. These are the two paintings I want you to stand in front of in this room.

Look first at The Embrace. Two figures clasped together. The bodies are heavy, monumental, almost geometric. Arms thick as columns. The flesh isn't soft — it's modeled like sculpture, with smooth volumes and almost no surface detail. The faces are simplified into mask-like forms. This is Picasso in 1922 or 1923, after Cubism, after the First World War, deliberately reaching backward — toward Roman frescoes, toward Greek sculpture, toward what painters across Europe were calling *rappel à l'ordre*. Return to order.

What does that mean? The First World War had just ended. Twenty million dead. The certainties of the European nineteenth century had collapsed. And in the years immediately after the war, painters who had been the most radical experimentalists — Picasso, Derain, Matisse — pulled back. They returned to clearly recognizable bodies. They referenced classical antiquity. They painted in ways their grandfathers would have understood.

Why? There's no single answer. Some scholars say it was a response to trauma — the world needed steadiness, not fracture, after four years of unimaginable destruction. Some say it was a cultural retrenchment, a defensive move against the radical left. Some say Picasso himself just wanted to prove he could draw a body. He'd been accused, by the Cubist years, of not being able to. He responded by drawing some of the most academically perfect bodies anyone had drawn in fifty years.

Now look at Large Bather. This is the painting where the classicism gets most explicit. A massive woman, seated, naked, monumental. She could be a temple statue. The body is twice the scale you'd expect. The skin is rendered like marble. The pose echoes ancient sculptures of Aphrodite or seated goddesses. Picasso was reaching for things that had been made two thousand years before him.

But — and this is the Picasso twist — look closely at her face. Look at her eyes. There's something not quite right. The proportions are off in a deliberate way. The classicism is a costume. Picasso never fully left Cubism behind. He was the kind of painter who could play in any style, and play with that style, and never be entirely inside it. The Large Bather looks classical. She is, somewhere underneath, still Picasso.

These paintings sit in this room because Domenica Walter found them comfortable. Big bodies. Recognizable forms. Classical references. She liked Picasso when he was being graceful. She didn't keep him when he was being difficult.

Next is Matisse. The room is just through the next opening.

Matisse — The Three Sisters Triptych

Plus the odalisques — color as architecture

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Move to the Matisse room. Ten Matisse paintings.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

Three panels of women, hung side by side as a triptych. And several odalisque paintings — figures in patterned domestic interiors.

LISTEN FOR

Why Matisse is fundamentally a colorist — and how the Three Sisters becomes architecture made of color.

Ten Matisses in this collection. The most important grouping in this room is the triptych of The Three Sisters — Les Trois Soeurs — three paintings hung side by side that show the same young woman three times in slightly different poses and costumes. Matisse painted them between 1916 and 1917, during the First World War, while Monet was painting his water lilies eighty miles away in Giverny.

Stand in front of them. Let your eye move across all three.

The dominant color is a deep saturated black-green-blue. Each figure is set against this dark ground. The clothing — striped fabric, a patterned sash, a flat-colored dress — interrupts the dark background with deliberate pieces of contrasting color. Reds. Yellows. Pinks. Whites. The figures themselves are simplified. The faces are masks. The hands are minimal. The bodies are arranged with the same flatness Matisse had been working toward for fifteen years.

This is what Matisse meant when he said his goal was an art "of balance, of purity and serenity, devoid of troubling subject matter, like a good armchair." Look at how this triptych works. Three calm figures. Three balanced compositions. No drama. No narrative. Just three young women, against a deep dark backdrop, dressed in colors that interact across all three panels.

Matisse was fundamentally a colorist. Not in the way Renoir was a colorist — Renoir uses color to make flesh feel alive. Matisse uses color as architecture. The colors in The Three Sisters do the structural work that line and shading would have done in a Renaissance painting. The figure is built out of color blocks set next to each other. The dress is one block. The wall is another. The sash is a third. The whole composition holds together because of how those blocks of color answer each other across the painting.

Now move to the odalisques. The Walter-Guillaume collection has several. Look for a woman reclining on cushions, in a room filled with patterned fabrics and an Oriental rug. The mood is languid. The colors are warm. The patterns of the room — the carpet, the wallpaper, the textiles — are all painted as if they're as important as the figure.

Matisse made these in the 1920s, in Nice, on the Côte d'Azur. He had moved south for the light. He had a series of models who came to his studio and posed in costumes. The setting is theatrical — these aren't real harems, they're his Nice apartment dressed up with fabric. The paintings have been criticized for that. Some

critics see them as Orientalist fantasy, a wealthy Frenchman painting an imagined East. Others see them as careful color studies, where the actual subject is the relationship between a printed fabric and a body, between a pattern and a face.

Both are true. The odalisques exist in a tradition of Orientalist painting — Delacroix did it, Ingres did it, Renoir did it — and Matisse is working in that tradition with all of its complications. But what he's really doing, what makes these paintings still feel alive a century later, is the color work. Look at how a red sash sits next to a blue wall sits next to a yellow lampshade. The painting is a chord. Each part of it sounds against every other part.

When you've spent some time in front of the Three Sisters and at least one odalisque, you've understood the Matisse in this room.

Modigliani comes next. He's a heavier track — five paintings, one long sad life.

Modigliani — Five Portraits, One Long Loneliness

Amedeo Modigliani, dead at thirty-five

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Move into the Modigliani room. Five portraits, hung close together.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

Five long oval faces. Almond-shaped eyes — often empty, with no pupils. Stretched necks. Quiet, almost mournful subjects.

LISTEN FOR

Why Modigliani painted faces this way, and what was happening to him while he did it.

Five Modiglianis. Slow down here.

Amedeo Modigliani was born in Livorno, on the Tuscan coast, in 1884. He came to Paris in 1906, when he was twenty-two. He died there fourteen years later, in January 1920, of tubercular meningitis. He was thirty-five.

In those fourteen years he painted around three hundred works. He spent most of them poor. He drank heavily. He took drugs. He had affairs. He had a partner, Jeanne Hébuterne, who was nine months pregnant with his second child when he died, and who killed herself two days after his death by jumping out of her parents' apartment window. She was twenty-one.

That's the life that lies underneath these five paintings on this wall.

Now look at the paintings themselves. The faces are unmistakable. Long oval head, almost mask-like. The neck stretched, almost impossibly so. The eyes — and this is the key — most of them are empty. No pupils. Just almond-shaped slits filled with one solid color. Pale blue. Black. Sometimes nothing.

People often ask why he painted eyes that way. Modigliani is supposed to have given an answer himself, to one of his sitters who asked him to paint her eyes. He said: "When I know your soul, I'll paint your eyes." Until then, he painted the eyes empty. That's the line he reportedly used. It's been quoted for a hundred years and may have grown in the telling, but the impulse behind it is real. Modigliani treated the eyes not as physical features but as access to interiority. If he hadn't worked out who the sitter was — fully, deeply, by his own standard — he didn't put pupils in. The face stayed closed.

Find Paul Guillaume, *Novo Pilota* — the portrait of Paul Guillaume painted in 1915, when the young dealer was twenty-four and just two years into running his gallery. Modigliani painted it in oil on cardboard. Guillaume is wearing a dark suit. The face is the typical Modigliani oval, but here the eyes have pupils — Modigliani knew Guillaume well, by then, and painted them in. The title — *Novo Pilota*, "the new pilot" — is what Modigliani wrote on the canvas. He thought Guillaume was the new pilot of modern art. The new navigator. It's both flattering and slightly mocking, the way Modigliani's titles often were.

Look around at the other Modiglianis. Find *The Young Apprentice* — *Le Petit Apprenti* — painted in 1918 or 1919, near the end of his life. A young workman, probably a builder's assistant, in a blue jacket. The face

is elongated, the eyes almost blank, the body is patient and tired. He could be sixteen. Modigliani painted dozens of these young anonymous Parisians — apprentices, servants, models. They're not portraits of important people. They're portraits of the people who lived around the artist's studio, who could be paid a few francs to sit for an afternoon.

There's also a portrait of a woman named Antonia. Find her if she's on the wall. She has the same long neck, the same closed face, the same posture of weary stillness.

Standing in this room, look at the five of them. They share a kind of quiet sadness. Some art critics call it elegance. Some call it melancholy. Whatever you call it, it's coming from somewhere true. Modigliani didn't have time. He knew he was sick — he had been tubercular since adolescence, and his lungs got worse every year. He painted as fast as he could. He died penniless. He was buried in a borrowed grave.

A year after his death, a memorial exhibition of his work in Paris sold out. The prices doubled the year after that, and doubled again the year after that. By 1934, when Paul Guillaume himself died at forty-two — almost exactly the same age Modigliani had been — Modigliani's paintings were among the most sought-after modern works in Europe.

Take a minute in this room. Let his faces settle. We'll go to Soutine next, which is heavier still.

Soutine — The Pastry Cook, Page Boy, Carcass of Beef

Chaïm Soutine, 1893-1943 — paint as if the world is burning

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Walk into the Soutine room. Twenty-two paintings — the largest single-artist holding in the collection after Renoir and Derain.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

Crooked faces. Twisted bodies. Service workers in their uniforms — pastry cooks, bellboys. And one large painting of a slaughtered animal.

LISTEN FOR

Why Soutine painted the world this way, and what it cost him.

Twenty-two Soutines in this collection. Paul Guillaume bought them when nobody else wanted them. Domenica kept them all.

Chaïm Soutine was born in 1893 in a small Jewish village in what is now Belarus. The tenth of eleven children. His family was extremely poor. They were religiously observant, which meant his decision to study drawing as a child was scandalous — painting living things was forbidden under a strict reading of Jewish law. He was beaten for it. He left home as a teenager. He came to Paris in 1913, at age twenty, and lived for years in extreme poverty in the artists' commune called La Ruche — the Beehive — where he painted in an unheated studio that smelled, by every visitor's account, terrible. He hung carcasses in there to paint from. He didn't bathe. He couldn't afford to.

Paul Guillaume met him through the dealer Léopold Zborowski around 1919. Guillaume bought Soutine's paintings in bulk. He once acquired more than fifty Soutines in a single visit from a collector named Albert Barnes, who had bought them all at once from Soutine's previous dealer.

Look at the paintings now. Find The Little Pastry Cook — Le Petit Pâtissier. A young man in white uniform, with a crooked apron, leaning slightly. His ear is too red. His face is unsettled. The whole figure twists slightly to one side as if he can't quite stand straight.

Find the Page Boy — the bellboy. A red uniform. A small skewed body. The face anxious or angry, depending on how you read it.

Now find Carcass of Beef — Le Bœuf écorché. This is the most disturbing painting in this collection. A side of beef hangs in a slaughterhouse. The flesh is rendered in violent reds and yellows. The painting throbs.

Soutine made several paintings of carcasses. He had a real carcass hauled to his studio so he could paint it. As the days went by it began to rot. The smell drove his neighbors at La Ruche to call the police. They came to evict him. He refused to part with the carcass — he was still working on it. His friend, the sculptor Chana Orloff, talked the police down. Soutine continued painting. He poured fresh blood on the carcass periodically to keep the color right.

This is the level he worked at. He was not painting representations of subjects. He was painting the actual presence of decay, of meat, of bodies in distress. The pastry cooks and bellboys and grooms in the other

Soutines you see in this room — they're being painted with the same intensity. Soutine couldn't paint anything as if it were stable. The world, to him, was always quietly tilting.

In June 1940, Germany invaded France. Soutine was Jewish. He was hiding in the French countryside, moving from village to village. By 1943, he had developed a perforated ulcer. He was operated on in Paris — an urgent, dangerous operation that required him to leave hiding. He died of the surgery on August ninth, 1943, at age forty-nine. The Gestapo had been searching for him.

Look around this room one more time. These twenty-two paintings represent the work of a man who couldn't afford to eat, who painted in conditions that horrified his neighbors, and who was hunted in his last years. The paint itself is built up thick. The figures lean and twist. The colors are unstable. Soutine couldn't make the world hold still — and so he painted it the way it felt to him.

Paul Guillaume saw what Soutine was doing before almost anyone else. He bought his work for almost nothing. Today these paintings are among the most important holdings of Soutine's work anywhere in the world.

Three more downstairs artists, more briefly, in the next track.

Derain, Laurencin & Utrillo — The Quieter Voices

The School of Paris, in three keys

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Walk through the rooms holding the André Derain paintings, the Marie Laurencin works, and the Maurice Utrillo townscapes.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

Three different artists, three different moods. Derain's classical post-Fauve work. Laurencin's pastel female groups. Utrillo's Montmartre streets.

LISTEN FOR

Three more painters Paul Guillaume believed in, briefly summarized — because every visitor will at least pass through these rooms.

We're heading toward the staircase back up. But before we go, three more artists you'll walk past.

First, André Derain. The Walter-Guillaume collection has thirty-one Derain paintings — more than any other artist in this museum except for the Soutines and Renoirs. That's because Paul Guillaume was personally close to Derain, who lived nearby and was a regular visitor at the gallery.

Derain had been one of the original Fauves — the wild, color-saturated movement that scandalized Paris in 1905. By the time Paul Guillaume started collecting him, Derain had moved on. He had pulled back into something quieter, more classical. The Derains in this collection are mostly from the 1920s and 1930s. Find *Le Joueur de cornemuse* — *The Bagpipe Player* — or *Arlequin et Pierrot* — *Harlequin and Pierrot*. The colors are muted now. The figures stand still. The mood is melancholy, almost theatrical, like figures from a paused *commedia dell'arte*. Derain, in his later years, was looking at Caravaggio, at Italian primitives, at the deep European past. The wildness of his Fauve years had cooled. Some critics consider the late Derain a step backward. Others find a sustained dignity in it.

Now Marie Laurencin. The collection has seven of her paintings. Laurencin was one of the few women in the Paris avant-garde of the early twentieth century to make a living from her painting. She had been Apollinaire's lover for years. She kept her own studio. She painted, almost exclusively, women — in soft pastel pinks, pale blues, dove greys. Groups of women. Mothers and daughters. Friends. The faces are simplified, the bodies elongated, the palette deliberately gentle.

For decades Laurencin was condescended to. Critics called her work decorative, feminine, lightweight. In recent years, that consensus has been revisited. Laurencin made a specific deliberate choice to paint women, in a register of softness, without irony and without male commentary. It's a kind of feminism by aesthetic rather than by argument. Look at her group portraits in this room. They're not sentimental — they're patient.

Finally, Maurice Utrillo. Ten paintings. Utrillo painted streets — particularly the streets of Montmartre, the hilltop neighborhood in Paris where he was born and lived. White walls. Black shutters. Cobblestone slopes. The neighborhood as it looked in the 1910s and 1920s, captured by a man who knew every corner of it.

Utrillo's life was difficult. He was the son of the painter Suzanne Valadon, who had been Renoir's and Toulouse-Lautrec's model before becoming a painter herself. He started drinking heavily in his teens. He

spent stretches of his adult life institutionalized. His paintings of Montmartre were initially commercial — he made them, in part, to fund his alcohol. They became, over time, the most accurate visual record of Montmartre as a neighborhood. When the streets were later widened, when the cafés closed, when the working-class character of Montmartre disappeared into tourism, Utrillo's paintings became the closest thing to memory.

Walk through these three artists' rooms slowly. They're not the headline works of this collection, but they're the texture. They're who Paul Guillaume believed in. They're who Domenica kept.

Now — let's go back upstairs to the Water Lilies. The staircase or elevator is just ahead.

PART V — RETURN TO THE WATER LILIES

Three tracks. The second visit — and why it matters more than the first.

Coming Back Up — The Second Visit

Returning to the lilies after the downstairs collection

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Climb the stairs (or take the elevator) back to the ground floor. Pause at the entrance to the first oval room.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

The same rooms you walked through an hour ago. The same eight compositions of water lilies. But the light may have shifted, and you've changed.

LISTEN FOR

What's different about seeing the lilies the second time.

Take a breath at the top of the stairs.

The Water Lilies room is right in front of you again. The same room you walked through an hour, an hour and a half ago. The same compositions. Morning. Setting Sun. Clouds. Green Reflections. They haven't moved. They haven't changed.

But something has changed. Two things, actually.

The first is the light. Depending on how long you've been downstairs, the natural daylight coming through the skylights is probably a different color than it was when you first walked in. If you came in on a bright morning, it may be afternoon now — the light warmer, more golden. If you arrived in the afternoon, it may be late afternoon — softer, lower, the panels reading differently. Monet wanted these rooms lit by daylight precisely so that they would never look the same twice. The light is what makes the paintings move.

The second thing that's changed is you.

Think about who and what you've just walked through. Modigliani, dead at thirty-five. Soutine, hunted by the Gestapo. Rousseau, mocked his whole life for paintings that turned out to be foundational. Paul Guillaume, dead at forty-two with his dream of a museum unrealized. Renoir's hands, ruined by arthritis but still painting. Cézanne, patiently building the world out of small planes of color while everyone in Paris was making fun of him. Picasso, returning to classical bodies after Cubism. Matisse, building rooms out of color.

You've spent an hour in a collection assembled by people who lived hard lives. Most of the painters downstairs died young or in difficult circumstances. Most of them were dismissed during their lifetimes. Most of them were preserved by a dealer who died at forty-two and a widow who outlived two husbands and never stopped buying.

And now you're walking back into the rooms that Monet designed at the end of his life, while he was nearly blind, after losing his wife, after losing a son, after listening to artillery from his garden for four years.

Some part of the second visit is just going to feel different. There's no specific instruction I can give you for it. The lilies will be what they are. But your relationship to them changes when you've spent time downstairs.

Walk in. The first composition you'll see again is, probably, *Morning*. Go to it. Take it in. We'll talk about what Monet actually built, architecturally, in the next track.

What Monet Built Here — The Oval Rooms as Architecture

The first installation art, made for paintings

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Stand near the center of the first oval room.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

Look up at the skylight. Look around at the curved walls. Look down at the bench in the center. Notice the architecture.

LISTEN FOR

Why these rooms are sometimes called the first installation artwork in modern art.

Look around this room. Not at the paintings. At the room itself.

The walls are curved. They form a continuous oval, with no corners. The ceiling is white, with a skylight in the middle — a circle of glass and stretched fabric scrim that lets daylight in but diffuses it so nothing creates a glare on the canvases. There's a bench in the center of the room, low enough that you can sit and still see all four compositions at once. The floor is a quiet polished stone.

Now — here's what makes this a remarkable space, beyond the paintings inside it.

Monet didn't just donate the panels. He designed the rooms. He worked with the architect Camille Lefèvre, but the spatial concept was his. He insisted on the oval shape. He insisted on natural light from above. He insisted that the panels be mounted directly onto the curved walls, with no breaks between panels — so the seams between the canvas sections would disappear. He insisted on the proportions of the rooms relative to the paintings. He insisted that nothing else be displayed in here. No sculpture. No other paintings. No furniture except the central bench. Nothing to compete with the lilies.

In other words, Monet didn't just give France eight compositions of water lilies. He gave France two rooms full of water lilies. The rooms are part of the work.

This is, by some accounts, the first piece of installation art in modern Western painting. The room is not a neutral container. The room is part of what you're looking at. Without these specific walls, this specific light, this specific oval shape, the paintings would mean something different. They were made for this space. They've never left it.

It also explains why the renovation in the early two thousands was so significant. Between roughly the 1960s and 2006, the Orangerie had been altered — a second floor was added inside the building, and the Water Lilies were displayed under electric light, with a suspended false ceiling above them blocking the original skylights. The natural light Monet had insisted on was gone for nearly forty years. People who came to the Orangerie before 2006 saw the lilies, but they didn't see them in the light Monet intended.

In 2000, a full renovation began. The architect Olivier Brochet ran the project. The added inner floor was demolished. The false ceiling came down. The skylights were restored. The natural light came back. The Walter-Guillaume collection — which had been on the ground floor — was moved downstairs to newly

excavated basement rooms, where it lives now. The Orangerie reopened in 2006, returned, finally, to the configuration Monet had asked for in the 1920s.

So what you're standing in right now is, more or less, what Monet wanted. The light is right. The space is right. The paintings are mounted as he asked. It took the museum eighty years and four major renovations to get back to where it started.

One more track in here, before we walk out. The next one is just for sitting.

Sitting in the Silence — One Last Look

The bench, the light, the lilies

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Sit down on the bench in the center of either oval room — whichever feels right.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

Whatever the light is showing you right now. The composition closest to your face. The slow soft pulse of daylight through the scrim above.

LISTEN FOR

Not much. This track is mostly quiet.

Sit down. Get comfortable.

This is the part of the tour I don't really need to talk through. So I'm going to step back, and let you have a few minutes with the lilies.

There's a bench in the middle of each oval room. If you can find one with space — sit. If there's no room on the bench, just stand somewhere quiet, with your back against a wall maybe, and look.

Don't try to think about the paintings now. Don't try to remember what was said about which composition. Don't try to figure out which willow is which. Just look at whatever's in front of you. Let the colors do what they're going to do.

Monet's hope for these rooms was that they would offer, in his words, an asylum of peaceful meditation. He said that out loud, in 1909, before he had finished a single panel of what's now in here. He spent the rest of his life — seventeen more years — trying to make that hope true. He gave them to France in 1918, the day after the war ended. The rooms opened in 1927, five months after he died. He never saw them like this. He never sat where you're sitting.

If you've been in the museum for an hour or more, you may notice your body has slowed. Your shoulders may be lower. Your breathing may be different. That's the lilies working. That's what they were made for.

There's a thing that happens in this room, that visitors describe sometimes. The paintings start to feel like they're moving. Not literally moving — but their surface starts to dissolve into something like real water. The reflections separate slightly from the lily pads. The willows seem to drift. Some visitors say they start to feel the wind on the water. None of that is in the paintings, of course. It's all in the looking.

It's also why Monet didn't want photographs of these. He didn't want them reproduced. He said photographs killed them. He was right. You can buy postcards of these compositions in the museum shop, and they're not wrong — the colors are accurate, the shapes are accurate. But the paintings aren't shapes and colors. They're a relationship between the painted surface and your standing body, in this light, in this room, right now.

So sit. Don't move for a while.

Think about whatever you want to think about. Or don't think. The lilies will keep doing what they do whether you're paying attention or not.

When you're ready, when something in you says it's time, stand up slowly. Walk out at your own pace. The doors are over there — through the corridor, past the entrance, back into Paris.

Take your time. We'll meet you outside.

PART VI — CLOSING

Two tracks. Walking out, practical information, and goodbye.

Walking Out — The Tuileries, the Concorde, the Seine

Where to go from here, if you've got time

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Outside the museum, back in the Jardin des Tuileries. Pause for a moment in the gravel.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

The garden. The Place de la Concorde. The Seine. Whatever Paris is doing today.

LISTEN FOR

Three good directions to walk, if you don't have to be anywhere right away.

You're outside. Take a breath of actual outdoor air.

You're standing in the Jardin des Tuileries — one of the oldest formal gardens in Paris, originally designed for Catherine de Medici in the sixteenth century and reworked by André Le Nôtre in the seventeenth. The gravel, the rows of trees, the long axis of the central walkway — all of it is essentially Le Nôtre's design, kept in place for three and a half centuries.

If you have time, here are three directions you can walk from where you are.

First option: east, through the Tuileries, toward the Louvre. It's about a fifteen-minute walk straight up the central path. You'll pass statues, fountains, possibly an open-air carousel for children, and end up at the Louvre's pyramid courtyard. The Louvre is the biggest museum in the world. You can't see it in one visit. But just standing in the courtyard of the Cour Napoléon, with the pyramid in front of you and the old palace wrapped around it on three sides — that's worth ten minutes by itself.

Second option: west, to the Place de la Concorde. Just a few minutes' walk. Concorde is the largest public square in Paris. The obelisk in the center is over three thousand years old — taken from the temple of Luxor in Egypt and erected here in 1836. The square is also where the guillotine stood during the Reign of Terror, in 1793 and 1794, when over a thousand people were executed there, including Louis the Sixteenth and Marie Antoinette. There's no marker. The square just continues, beautiful, terrible, holding it all.

Third option: cross the river. You're a few minutes from the Pont de la Concorde, the bridge that crosses the Seine just south of where you're standing. On the other side is the Quai d'Orsay, and a five-minute walk along it brings you to the Musée d'Orsay — the great companion museum to the Orangerie, holding most of the impressionist and post-impressionist paintings of nineteenth-century France. The Orangerie and the Orsay have been administratively linked since 2010. If you have energy left and the Orsay is open, it's a natural next stop.

Or — and this is the option I'd actually recommend most days — just stay in the Tuileries. Find a chair. They're free. Sit by one of the round basins. Watch the children push their toy sailboats with sticks. Watch the pigeons. The Orangerie doesn't ask you to do anything next. The lilies are still in your head. Let them stay there for a while before you go back into normal Paris.

One last track. Practical information you might need. Then we're done.

Practical Info & Goodbye

Hours, tickets, the Rousseau exhibition, and a few small things

STOP & LOOK

WHERE

Wherever you are. On a bench, in the Tuileries, on the métro, walking somewhere.

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

Nothing in particular. This track is just information.

LISTEN FOR

Hours, current exhibitions, what's near, how to come back.

A few practical notes before we say goodbye.

The Orangerie is open every day except Tuesdays, from nine in the morning to six in the evening. The last admission is at five-fifteen, and the rooms start closing at five-thirty. During exhibition periods there are sometimes Friday late nights — open until nine, with reduced admission after six. The museum is closed on three French holidays each year: May the first, July the fourteenth in the morning only, and December the twenty-fifth.

Tickets. You can buy them at the door, but you'll wait in line. Online reservation through billetterie.musee-orangerie.fr is faster and lets you walk straight in within a thirty-minute window of your reserved time. The Paris Museum Pass also gets you in, but you still need a reservation. EU citizens under twenty-six get free admission. The first Sunday of every month is free for everyone, but you still need to reserve a time slot — and it gets crowded.

A current event worth knowing about. There's a major temporary exhibition on right now: Henri Rousseau, *The Ambition of Painting*. It runs through July twentieth of this year, 2026. If you came to the museum mainly for the *Water Lilies* and you only have time for one extra thing, the Rousseau show is the one to see — especially after walking through the Rousseaus in the permanent collection just now. The exhibition argues for Rousseau as a serious ambitious painter, not the naïve curiosity history has sometimes made him.

After July, the next major show is *Monet and Time*, opening in late September and running through March of next year. That one will explore how Monet captured the passage of time in his series paintings, including the *Water Lilies*. If you can get to Paris during the run, it's worth a return trip.

A small note on what's around the museum. The Tuileries Garden cafés are decent for a coffee. There's a bookshop at the Orangerie itself, on the lower level — good for catalogs and prints, including the giant infinity-symbol floor plan postcard. Around the corner on the rue de Rivoli, you'll find the standard tourist arcade, and a few quieter side streets if you walk a couple of blocks north.

That's the practical part.

A few words to close. Thank you for walking through this museum with me. The Orangerie is small — you can do it in an hour. But it rewards going slowly. I hope we went slowly. I hope the *Water Lilies* opened up for you a little more on the second visit than the first. I hope you found at least one painting downstairs that

wasn't on your list of things you came to see, and that surprised you. That's what a good museum visit does. It introduces you to things you didn't know you were going to meet.

The Musée de l'Orangerie holds two of the deepest collections of modern painting anywhere in the world. Both of them came out of difficult lives. Both of them were built by people who refused to let their work be small.

Walk gently the rest of the day. À bientôt.